Meanwhile, the people of Toulouse suffered from hunger and disease, lost crops and slaughtered livestock, burned homes and fields.

By fall, Pedro and Raymond had decided to mount a direct attack on Montfort's most central fortification, the castle at Muret: "a garrison," writes William of Puylaurens, "which was causing great difficulties for the city of Toulouse." They were joined by a "great many men" from the neighboring territories. Simon de Montfort's violent and unceasing campaigning had increasingly seemed less for the church than for himself, and the local nobility wanted him gone, crusade or no crusade.[8]

On September 12, a sizable army of knights from Aragon and Toulouse attacked Muret. With only fifteen hundred men at his disposal, the badly outnumbered Simon de Montfort managed to rout them. The king of Aragon was "so severely wounded," says the anonymous conclusion to William of Tudela's account, "that his blood spilled out on the ground and he fell his full length dead." His men scattered, many of them drowning as they tried to flee back across the Garonne.

Raymond too was forced to flee. Simon de Montfort marched into Toulouse and claimed it as his own. He had won control now of all of Languedoc; and Pedro II, victor over the Muslim enemy, had fallen at the hands of his Christian brothers.[9]

Young James, his heir, was still in the hands of Montfort. The people of Aragon pled with Innocent III to order his release, and Montfort reluctantly obeyed. But with a five-year-old king on the throne, Aragon remained in chaos. "Happy would Pedro have been," a Castilian account lamented, "had he concluded his life immediately after the noble triumph in the battle of Las Navas de Tolosa."[10]